

2c. Content of Developments in Christian thought (H573/03)

In this component, learners have the opportunity to undertake a systematic study of key concepts within the development of Christian thought.

Learners will explore religious beliefs, values and teachings, their interconnections, how they have developed historically and how they are presently discussed.

The first section explores human nature in the context of the purpose of life, the self and immortality. Learners will explore Augustine's ideas regarding the human condition, as well as different Christian interpretations of the promise and nature of the afterlife.

In *Knowledge of God*, both natural and revealed theology will be studied, including the relationship between faith and reason. This will enable discussion of how Christians may understand their relationship with God.

Learners will also explore historical and theological understandings of the person of Jesus Christ. They will consider Jesus as the Son of God, teacher of wisdom and a liberator, which will give them an insight into both traditional and contemporary Christian theology.

In the topic *Christian Moral Principles*, learners will consider the Bible, Church and reason as sources of wisdom and authority. Through considering the use of these in shaping Christian moral values and practice, this topic will allow learners to investigate the principles that shape and express religious

identity, and the diversity of practice within Christianity.

In *Christian Moral Action*, learners will undertake a detailed study of the ideas and impact of Dietrich Bonhoeffer. This study of Christian moral principles in action will place moral principles in a real-world context, making the study of Christianity more tangible for learners.

A significant development in Christian thought studied is that of pluralism, a vital concept in this age of migration and multi-cultural societies. The two topics which explore this concept enable the consideration of the ways that Christian traditions view other religious and non-religious worldviews. This raises issues of the nature of salvation, religious tolerance, respect and recognition of opposing views.

The changing roles of men and women, and feminist approaches to theology, form the basis of the two further topics. These topics encourage learners to reflect on issues of gender identity, equality and discrimination and the social influence of religious institutions, and provide the opportunity to compare the works of two key scholars.

Finally, this component explores the challenges posed by secularism, and a range of responses to this. These topics enable the study of how developments in beliefs and practices have, over time, influenced and been influenced by developments in philosophy, politics and studies of religion, as well as an investigation into the diversity within Christian practice.

Technical Terms

While the majority of non-English terms (which are not names of texts, philosophical schools, or particular religious approaches) within the specification and assessment materials will be accompanied by a translation, there are some which are considered to be key technical terms that learners are expected to recognise and understand without a provided translation.

For this component, the following are considered technical terms and will not necessarily be accompanied by a translation:

- *agape*.

1. Insight <i>Beliefs, teachings and ideas about human life, the world and ultimate reality</i>		
Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Augustine's Teaching on Human Nature*	Human relationships pre- and post-Fall	- Augustine's interpretation of Genesis 3 (the Fall) including: - the state of perfection before the Fall and Adam and Eve's relationship as friends - lust and selfish desires after the Fall
	Original Sin and its effects on the will and human societies	- Augustine's teaching that Original Sin is passed on through sexual intercourse and is the cause of: - human selfishness and lack of free will - lack of stability and corruption in all human societies
	God's grace	Augustine's teaching that only God's grace, his generous love, can overcome sin and the rebellious will to achieve the greatest good (<i>summum bonum</i>)
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Augustine's ideas on human nature, including: - whether or not Augustine's teaching on a historical Fall and Original Sin is wrong - whether or not Augustine is right that sin means that humans can never be morally good - whether or not Augustine's view of human nature is pessimistic or optimistic - whether or not there is a distinctive human nature		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Augustine listed above can be found in:</i> <i>City of God</i>, Book 14, Chapters 16–26 <i>Confessions</i>, Book 8 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Chapman, G. (1994) <i>Catechism of the Catholic Church</i> paras. 385–409 - McGrath, A. E. (2010 5th Edition) <i>Christian Theology</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, pages 348–355, 371–372 - Romans 7:15–20		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Death and the Afterlife*	- Christian teaching on: - heaven - hell - purgatory - election	- different interpretations of heaven, hell and purgatory, including: - heaven, hell and purgatory are actual places where a person may go after death and experience physical and emotional happiness, punishment or purification - heaven, hell and purgatory are not places but spiritual states that a person experiences as part of their spiritual journey after death - heaven, hell and purgatory are symbols of a person's spiritual and moral life on Earth and not places or states after death - different Christian views of who will be saved, including: - limited election (that only a few Christians will be saved) - unlimited election (that all people are called to salvation but not all are saved) - universalist belief (that all people will be saved) - the above to be studied with reference to the key ideas in Jesus' parable on Final Judgement, 'The Sheep and the Goats' (Matthew 25:31–46)
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian ideas on death and the afterlife, including: - whether or not God's judgement takes place immediately after death or at the end of time - whether or not hell and heaven are eternal - whether or not heaven is the transformation and perfection of the whole of creation - whether or not purgatory is a state through which everyone goes		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Chapman, G. (1994) <i>Catechism of the Catholic Church</i> paras. 356–368, 1020–1050 - Hick, J. (1985) <i>Death and Eternal Life</i>, Palgrave Macmillan, Part III - McGrath, A. E. (2011) <i>Theology: the Basics</i>, Blackwell, Chapter 8 - Revelation 20: 2–6, 7–15 and 21:1–8		

2. Foundations

The origins and development of Christianity, and the sources of wisdom on which it is based

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Knowledge of God's Existence*	- Natural knowledge of God's existence: - as an innate human sense of the divine - as seen in the order of creation - Revealed knowledge of God's existence: - through faith and God's grace - revealed knowledge of God in Jesus Christ	- as all humans are made in God's image they have an inbuilt capacity and desire to know God, including: - human openness to beauty and goodness as aspects of God - human intellectual ability to reflect on and recognise God's existence - what can be known of God can be seen in the apparent design and purpose of nature - as humans are sinful and have finite minds, natural knowledge is not sufficient to gain full knowledge of God; knowledge of God is possible through: - faith - grace as God's gift of knowledge of himself through the Holy Spirit - full and perfect knowledge of God is revealed in the person of Jesus Christ and through: - the life of the Church - the Bible
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian ideas on knowledge of God, including: - whether or not God can be known through reason alone - whether or not faith is sufficient reason for belief in God's existence - whether or not the Fall has completely removed all natural human knowledge of God - whether or not natural knowledge of God is the same as revealed knowledge of God - whether or not belief in God's existence is sufficient to put one's trust in him		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Romans 1:18–21 - Calvin, J. <i>Institutes of the Christian Religion</i> I.I and I.II - Acts 17:16–34		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The person of Jesus Christ*	- Jesus Christ's authority as: - the Son of God	- Jesus' divinity as expressed in his: - knowledge of God - miracles - resurrection With reference to Mark 6:47–52 and John 9:1–41
	a teacher of wisdom	- Jesus' moral teaching on: - repentance and forgiveness - inner purity and moral motivation With reference to Matthew 5:17–48 and Luke 15:11–32
	a liberator	- Jesus' role as liberator of the marginalised and the poor, as expressed in his: - challenge to political authority - challenge to religious authority With reference to Mark 5:24–34 and Luke 10:25–37
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian ideas regarding Jesus Christ as a source of authority, including: - whether or not Jesus was only a teacher of wisdom - whether or not Jesus was more than a political liberator - whether or not Jesus' relationship with God was very special or truly unique - whether or not Jesus thought he was divine		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - McGrath, A. (2011) <i>Theology: the Basics</i>, Blackwell, Chapter 4 - Theissen, G. (2010) <i>The Shadow of the Galilean</i>, SCM Press - Chapman, G. (1994) <i>Catechism of the Catholic Church</i> paras. 422–478		

3. Living

The diversity of ethics and practice, including those that shape and express religious identity, the role of the community of believers and key moral principles

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Christian moral principles*	- The diversity of Christian moral reasoning and practices and sources of ethics, including: - the Bible as the only authority for Christian ethical practices - Bible, Church and reason as the sources of Christian ethical practices - love (<i>agape</i>) as the only Christian ethical principle which governs Christian practices	- as the Bible reveals God's will, then only biblical ethical commands must be followed - Christian ethics must be a combination of biblical teaching, Church teaching and human reason - Jesus' only command was to love and that human reason must decide how best to apply this
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to diversity of Christian moral principles, including: - whether or not Christian ethics are distinctive - whether or not Christian ethics are personal or communal - whether or not the principle of love is sufficient to live a good life - whether or not the Bible is a comprehensive moral guide	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Exodus 20:1–17 1 Corinthians 13:1–7 - Messer, N. (2006) <i>SCM Study Guide to Christian Ethics</i>, SCM Press	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Christian moral action*	- The teaching and example of Dietrich Bonhoeffer on: - duty to God and duty to the State - Church as community and source of spiritual discipline - the cost of discipleship	- Bonhoeffer's teaching on the relationship of Church and State including: - obedience, leadership and doing God's will - justification of civil disobedience - Bonhoeffer's role in the Confessing Church and his own religious community at Finkenwalde - Bonhoeffer's teaching on ethics as action, including: 'costly grace' - sacrifice and suffering - solidarity
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian moral action in the life and teaching of Bonhoeffer, including: - whether or not Christians should practise civil disobedience - whether or not it is possible always to know God's will - whether or not Bonhoeffer puts too much emphasis on suffering - whether or not Bonhoeffer's theology has relevance today		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Bonhoeffer listed above can be found in:</i> - Bonhoeffer, D. (1951) <i>Letters and Papers from Prison</i> and (1937) <i>The Cost of Discipleship</i>, Chapter 1 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Romans 13:1–7 <i>Barmen Declaration</i> (www.sacred-texts.com/chr/barmen.htm) - Luke 10:38–42		

4. Development

Significant social and historical developments in Christian thought, such as those influenced by ethics, philosophy or studies of religion

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Religious pluralism and theology	- The teaching of contemporary Christian theology of religion on: - exclusivism - inclusivism - pluralism	- the view that only Christianity fully offers the means of salvation - the view that although Christianity is the normative means of salvation, 'anonymous' Christians may also receive salvation - the view that there are many ways to salvation, of which Christianity is one path
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to religious pluralism and Christian theology of religion, including: - whether or not if Christ is the 'truth' there can be any other means of salvation - whether or not a loving God would ultimately deny any human being salvation - whether or not all good people will be saved - whether or not theological pluralism undermines central Christian beliefs	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Hick, J. (1995) <i>God and the Universe of Faiths</i>, SCM Press, Chapters 1 and 10 - McGrath, A. E. (2010 5th Edition) <i>Christian Theology</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, Chapter 17 - D'Costa, G. (2009) <i>Christianity and World Religions</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, Chapter 5	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Religious pluralism and society	- the development of contemporary multi-faith societies - Christian responses to, including: - responses of Christian communities to inter-faith dialogue - the scriptural reasoning movement	- the reasons for this development, for example migration - how Christian communities have responded to the challenge of encounters with other faiths, for example: - Catholic Church: <i>Redemptoris Missio</i> 55–57 - Church of England: <i>Sharing the Gospel of Salvation</i> - its methods and aims - how the mutual study and interpretation of different religions' sacred literature can help understanding of different and conflicting religious truth claims
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian responses to multi-faith societies and inter-faith dialogue, including: - whether or not inter-faith dialogue has contributed practically towards social cohesion - whether or not Christian communities should seek to convert people from other faiths - whether or not scriptural reasoning relativises religious beliefs - whether or not Christians should have a mission to those of no faith	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful - The Doctrine Commission of the Church of England (1995) <i>The Mystery of Salvation</i> Church House Publishing, Chapter 7 - Ford, D. (2011) <i>The Future of Christian Theology</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, Chapter 7 - Pope Paul VI (1965) <i>Nostra Aetate; Declaration on the relation of the Church to non-Christian religions</i>	

5. Society

The relationship between religion and society, including issues such as how religions adapt when encountering different cultures; religious tolerance, respect and recognition and views of other religions and non-religious worldviews; religion, equality and discrimination; the political and social influence of religious institutions

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Gender and society	- The effects of changing views of gender and gender roles on Christian thought and practice, including: - Christian teaching on the roles of men and women in the family and society - Christian responses to contemporary secular views about the roles of men and women in the family and society	- including reference to: - Ephesians 5:22–33 <i>Mulieris Dignitatem</i> 18–19 - the ways in which Christians have adapted and challenged changing attitudes to family and gender, including issues of: - motherhood/parenthood - different types of family
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to Christian responses to changing views of gender and gender roles, including: - whether or not official Christian teaching should resist current secular views of gender - whether or not secular views of gender equality have undermined Christian gender roles - whether or not motherhood is liberating or restricting - whether or not the idea of family is entirely culturally determined	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Tong, R. (2013) <i>Feminist Thought</i>, Routledge, Chapter 1 - McGrath, A. E. (2010 5th Edition) <i>Christian Theology</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, pages 88–89, 336–337 - Messer, N. (2006) <i>SCM Study Guide to Christian Ethics</i>, SCM Press, Chapter 8. - Ephesians 5:21–33	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Gender and theology	- The reinterpretation of God by feminist theologians, including: - the teaching of Rosemary Radford Ruether and Mary Daly on gender and its implications for the Christian idea of God	- Ruether's discussion of the maleness of Christ and its implications for salvation including: - Jesus' challenge to the male warrior-messiah expectation - God as the female wisdom principle - Jesus as the incarnation of wisdom - Daly's claim that 'if God is male then the male is God' and its implications for Christianity, including: - Christianity's 'Unholy Trinity' of rape, genocide and war - spirituality experienced through nature
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to God, gender and feminist theology, including: - a comparison of Ruether's and Daly's feminist theologies - sexism and patriarchy in Christianity, as it has developed in the mainstream Churches - whether Christianity can be changed or should be abandoned - whether or not Christianity is essentially sexist - whether or not a male saviour can save women - whether or not only women can develop a genuine spirituality - whether or not the Christian God can be presented in female terms		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Radford Ruether and Daly listed above can be found in:</i> - Radford Ruether, R. <i>Sexism and God-Talk</i>, Chapter 9 - Daly, M. <i>Beyond God the Father</i>, Chapter 4 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Phyllis Trible, P. (1984) <i>Texts of Terror</i>, Fortress Press, Introduction and Chapter 2 - Wilcockson, M. (2010) <i>Social Ethics</i>, Hodder Education, Chapter 2 - Luke 24:9–12 - Acts 16:13–15		

6. Challenges

Challenges facing religious thought from areas such as science, secularisation, migration and multi-cultural societies and changing gender roles

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The Challenge of Secularism	- The rise of secularism and secularisation, and the views that: - God is an illusion and the result of wish fulfilment - Christianity should play no part in public life	- the views of Freud and Dawkins that society would be happier without Christianity as it is infantile, repressive and causes conflict - the views of secular humanists that Christian belief is personal and should play no part in public life, including: - education and schools - government and the state
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the challenge of secularism, including: - whether or not spiritual values are just human values - whether or not there is evidence that Christianity is a major cause of personal and social problems - whether secularism and secularisation are opportunities for Christianity to develop new ways of thinking and acting - whether Christianity is, or should be, a significant contributor to society's culture and values	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Dawkins and Freud listed above can be found in:</i> - Freud, S. <i>The Future of an Illusion</i> - Dawkins, R. <i>The God Delusion</i>, Chapter 9 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Ford, D. (2011) <i>The Future of Christian Theology</i>, Wiley-Blackwell, Chapters 3 and 6 - British Humanist Society, https://humanism.org.uk/ - Dawson, C. (1956) 'The Challenge of Secularism' in <i>Catholic World</i>, also online http://www.catholiceducation.org/en/education/catholic-contributions/the-challenge-of-secularism.html	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Liberation Theology and Marx	- The relationship of liberation theology and Marx, including: - Marx's teaching on alienation and exploitation - liberation theology's use of Marx to analyse social sin - liberation theology's teaching on the 'preferential option for the poor'	- alienation occurs when humans are dehumanised and unable to live fulfilling lives - exploitation occurs when humans are treated as objects and used as a means to an end - liberation theology's use of Marxist analysis to analyse the deeper or 'structural' causes of social sin that have resulted in poverty, violence and injustice, including: - capitalism - institutions (for example schools, churches, the state) - the view that the Gospel demands that Christians must give priority to the poor and act in solidarity with them, including implications of this: - placing right action (orthopraxis) before official Church teaching (orthodoxy)
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to liberation theology and Marx, including: - whether or not Christian theology should engage with atheist secular ideologies - whether or not Christianity tackles social issues more effectively than than Marxism - whether or not liberation theology has engaged with Marxism fully enough - whether or not it is right for Christians to prioritise one group over another	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Boff, L. and Boff, C. (1987) <i>Introducing Liberation Theology</i>, Burns and Oates - Gutierrez, G. (1974/2000) <i>A Theology of Liberation</i>, SCM Press, Chapter 4 - Congregation of the Doctrine of the Faith (1984) <i>Instruction on Certain Aspects of the 'Theology of Liberation'</i> - Wilcockson, M. (2011) <i>Christian Theology</i>, Hodder Education, Chapter 7	